

Lesson 5: Finding Your First Opportunities

What You'll Do Today

You already have a priced service package from Lessons 3–4. Today you're not going to advertise it to strangers on the internet. Instead, you're going to map out the people and organizations you **already know** — your "warm network" — and figure out who could realistically be your first real client, safely.

Why This Matters

It's tempting to think the fastest way to get a client is to post online where anyone can see it, or message strangers who might need your service. That feels like "real" business. But at your age, and honestly at any age, that's the harder and riskier path. The people most likely to actually hire you are people who already trust you or your family — a club you're in, a family friend, a local business your parents know, a teacher who's seen your work.

Warm Network vs. Cold Outreach

- **Warm network:** People and organizations you or your family already have a real relationship with. They know your name, or one introduction from someone you trust gets you connected. Examples: a club or team you're part of, a family friend, a neighbor, a teacher, your parents' coworkers, a local shop your family visits.
- **Cold outreach:** Reaching out to someone you have no connection to at all — a stranger online, a random business that's never heard of you, an anonymous post hoping someone bites.

Why warm-network-first is safer and more realistic for your first opportunity: 1. **Trust is already there.**

Someone who knows you (or knows someone who knows you) is far more likely to actually say yes than a stranger who has no reason to trust a teenager they've never met. 2. **An adult is naturally already involved.** Every entry in your warm network connects back to someone — you, your parents, a teacher — who already knows the people involved. That means a trusted adult can be part of the conversation from the start, instead of you navigating a stranger alone. 3. **It's how real first jobs actually happen.** Referrals — a person or organization pointing you toward another person who needs help — are how most people, at any age, land their first paying work.

A referral doesn't make your work less "real." A club project, a family friend's small job, or a school-sanctioned opportunity is a completely real client — real money, real deadline, real feedback — even though it started with someone you already knew.

Worked Example: Jordan R.

Jordan is 16 and built a flyer-design service package in Lessons 3–4 (\$15 per flyer, made in Canva). Instead of posting "flyer design, DM me" online, Jordan mapped their warm network:

Category	Person/Organization	Possible Need	How Jordan Would Reach Out	Adult Involved
School club	Yearbook Club	Event announcement flyers	Ask the club sponsor directly at the next meeting	Club sponsor (teacher)
Family friend	Mom's coworker (home baker)	Nicer price-list graphic	Mom mentions Jordan's service, coworker follows up with Mom	Jordan's mom
Local business/community org	Family dentist's office	Kids' dental-health month flyer	Dad asks the office manager, who he already knows	Jordan's dad
Teacher/mentor	Art teacher	PTA fall carnival flyer	Art teacher already offered to mention Jordan to the PTA	Art teacher + a parent
School-sanctioned platform	School activities job board	Posted design requests from clubs	Check the board weekly, apply through the school process	School staff moderating the board

Notice: every single row has a real adult attached before any actual client conversation happens. Jordan isn't messaging any of these people alone or out of the blue — a parent or teacher is part of the connection.

Key Terms

- **Warm network** — People and organizations you or your family already have a real relationship with.
- **Referral** — When someone you know points you toward another person or organization that might need your service.
- **Cold outreach** — Contacting someone you have no existing connection to, such as a stranger online or an unknown business.
- **Trusted adult** — A parent, guardian, teacher, or other adult in your life who is aware of and involved in any real client conversation.

Activity: Map Your Own Warm Network

Open your First Opportunity Map (Spreadsheet or Notion) and, for each category below, list at least 2 real people or organizations:

1. **School clubs/organizations** you're part of
2. **Family friends** your household actually knows
3. **Local small businesses or community organizations** your family has a real connection to

4. **Teachers or mentors** who know your work
5. **School-sanctioned platforms** (job boards, activity newsletters, etc.)

For every entry, write down: - What they might realistically need - How you'd reach out (through whom, not cold) - **A specific trusted adult** who would be aware of or part of that conversation

Then circle your top 3 to carry forward as "My First 3 Outreach Targets."

Knowledge Checks

1. What is the main difference between a warm network and cold outreach?
2. Give two reasons warm-network-first is safer for a first opportunity than messaging strangers online.
3. True or false: A client you found through a family friend is less "real" than one you found online. Explain your answer.
4. Name three categories of warm-network contacts covered in this lesson.
5. Why should a trusted adult be named for every entry on your First Opportunity Map, even the ones that feel low-stakes?

Reflection Prompts

1. Which category of your warm network surprised you with how many people/organizations you could list?
2. Which trusted adult in your life do you think could help you the most with a first opportunity, and why?
3. How did today change the way you think about what counts as a "real" first client?

Submission Instructions

Submit your completed First Opportunity Map (Spreadsheet or Notion link) with all 5 categories filled in, a trusted adult named on every row, and your "First 3 Outreach Targets" shortlisted. Submit your 5 knowledge check answers and 3 reflection responses in a Google Doc titled "Lesson 5 — [Your Name]." Your instructor will review before you move on to Lesson 6.